Gym Finder: Deployment Checklist

MongoDB Atlas (database) and Render (web service). Tick each box as you go.

> **Never paste the database password, the connection string or JWT_SECRET into git, the README, a chat or a screenshot. They go only into Render's environment settings and your own .env.local.**

Before you start

- ☐ Project is pushed to GitHub and npm run build passes on your computer
- ☐ Free MongoDB Atlas account created
- ☐ Free Render account created (signing in with GitHub is easiest)

Part 1: MongoDB Atlas

- ☐ Go to mongodb.com/cloud/atlas and sign in
- ☐ Create a project (for example gym-finder)
- ☐ Click Create / Build a Database and choose the Free (M0) tier
- ☐ Pick a provider and a region close to you, name the cluster, click Create
- ☐ Database Access > Add New Database User
  - Authentication: Password. Username such as gymfinder
  - Autogenerate Secure Password, copy it somewhere private (letters and numbers only is simplest)
  - Role: Read and write to any database. Click Add User
- ☐ Network Access > Add IP Address > Allow Access From Anywhere (0.0.0.0/0) > Confirm *Render's free tier has no fixed IP.*
- ☐ Database > Connect > Drivers (Node.js) > copy the connection string
- ☐ Replace <username> and <password> in it (no angle brackets). This is your MONGODB_URI
- ☐ Do not create a database or collections by hand *The app creates them on first save.*

Part 2: Make a JWT secret

- ☐ Run this on your computer and copy the output. It is your JWT_SECRET

```
node -e "console.log(require('crypto').randomBytes(32).toString('hex'))"
```

- ☐ Use a new secret for the live site, not the one in .env.local

Part 3: Render web service

- ☐ Go to render.com and sign in
- ☐ New + > Web Service > Build and deploy from a Git repository > Next
- ☐ Connect your GitHub account if asked, find the repository, click Connect

☐ Fill in the settings:

Setting	Value
Name	gym-finder (part of the web address)
Region	Closest to your Atlas region
Branch	The branch you want live (main, or dev if main is not ready)
Root Directory	Empty if the repo's top folder holds package.json, otherwise the subfolder name
Runtime / Language	Node
Build Command	npm install && npm run build
Start Command	npm start
Instance Type	Free

☐ Open Environment (or Advanced > Add Environment Variable) and add:

Key	Value
MONGODB_URI	The connection string from Part 1
DB_NAME	gym_finder
JWT_SECRET	The secret from Part 2
NODE_VERSION	22 (Next.js 16 needs Node 20.9 or newer)

DB_TEST_NAME is only for the tests, so it is not needed on Render. Render sets NODE_ENV=production, which makes the login cookie secure.

☐ Click Create Web Service and watch the Logs tab

☐ Wait until the status says Live, then note your address (for example https://gym-finder.onrender.com)

Part 4: Check the live site

☐ Home page loads with the search box

☐ Sign up as an owner (choose gym owner), password 8 to 50 characters

☐ My gyms > Add a gym, tick Offers a day pass, save. The gym shows on the dashboard

☐ Logout, then sign up as a member with a different email

☐ Search for the gym, open its page, click Get day pass. A code and today's date appear

☐ My passes lists the pass with a link to the gym

☐ Reload the gym page and click Get day pass again. You see the "already have a pass today" message

☐ Log out and open /passes. You land on the login page

Part 5: Finish

☐ Add the live address to README.md, for example Live site: https://gym-finder.onrender.com

☐ Commit with the message: Add deployment notes

If something goes wrong

Problem	What to check
First visit is very slow	Normal. The free service sleeps after about 15 minutes and takes up to a minute to wake.
Build fails with a Node version error	Set NODE_VERSION (Part 3) and redeploy.
Sign up or login says something went wrong on the server	Database connection. Check MONGODB_URI, that Atlas Network Access lists 0.0.0.0/0, and the Render Logs for a MongoDB connection error line.
Special characters in the password	@ : / must be URL-encoded. Easiest fix: make a new password with letters and numbers only.
Changed an environment variable	Save it under Environment. Render redeploys automatically.
Updating the live site	Push to the branch you chose. Render rebuilds on every push.
A secret leaked	Change the Atlas user's password or make a new JWT_SECRET in Render right away.